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,

(pronounced “Halfstop”)

A poetry chapbook written,
arranged, and printed
by Ryan El-Ouardighi

HEREIN ARE WRITTEN

“What does poetry do?”	6
friends.....	7
the rat race.....	8
The First Rays of the Rising Sun.....	9
The prisoner dreams to be free.....	10-11
Crossroads.....	12
.....	14-15
SECRET #5226.....	16
this poem was written.....	17
brilliance.....	18
lies.....	20
truths.....	21
Document 012 (“Life”).....	22-23
“What’s the reader doing?”	24-25

Author's Note

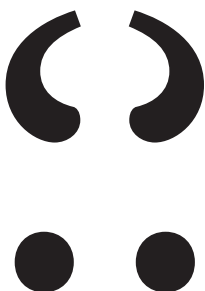


Hello again. I am Ryan El-Ouardighi, the author of the poems in this chapbook.

Since arranging *Humble Beginnings* earlier this year, I have been writing and evolving into something new; I am never one to stay the same.

; is a collection of my experimental poems. The title is derived from the half-stop that poetic tradition has taken in this chapbook and in my poetry in general—I occasionally use constraints such as rhyme or metre but typically refrain from it.

As always, thank you for reading.



“What does poetry do?”

nothing

...well, maybe some things

it sounds better on your tombstone

Here lies Ryan E.,

Poet

instead of

Here lies Ryan E.,

HVAC worker

are they really called “HVAC workers”?

maybe

“HVAC inspectors”

“HVAC installers”

“vent guys”

i like “vent guys” best.

...

wait, what was

your question again?

friends

i don't have them

the rat race

you are playing
against colleagues,
family,
strangers

3...

2...

1...

Go.

The First Rays of the Rising Sun

What do you do
when you see
The First Rays of the Rising Sun
spring onto the horizon?

Do you watch
and reflect on days past,
or look ahead
to the future?

I know what I do
when I am caught by
The First Rays of the Rising Sun;
I get up and work 'til my days end.

My drive has been weathered by time;
Yours hasn't.

The prisoner dreams to be free

The prisoner dreams to be free.
He wakes at morning and rests at
night,
consumed by the thought of

f
r
e
e
d
o
m
.

He not only longs—he tries.
He tries to escape endlessly,
each attempt more pointless than the
last.

“Doesn’t he ever learn?” his guard

The prisoner dreams to be free *cont'd*.

says.

“He ain’t gettin’ out any time soon.”

Someday, he will succeed.

He will stand with the breeze on his
back

and sigh, taking in his new reality.

But until then, his attempts continue,

motivated by nothing but the hope of
better days.

Crossroads

Crossroads of the valley:

One path, classic and neat.

The other, uncharted and dark.

Which—?

MAKE THE RIGHT CHOICE.

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;

A full heart's what I had that day,
A heart of gold, filled with love;
Yet gone it was as I left lovers' lane.

I caught the text on her iPhone,
The text from another man.
My blood ran cold and alone.

We argued for what felt like hours;
I said I couldn't believe her,
She said I never bought her flowers.

Soon I told her it was over,
And she agreed;
Like shredding a four-leaf clover.

She left me alone in my pain,
And I weeped for a while.
Then I drove, drove from lovers' lane.

lovers, Jane,
but we took a wrong turn

heart of gold,
but it turned too soon

the one for me,
but i was misled

sugar pie,
but switched for salt

couldn't help myself

touch'd the stove
was surprised when i got burnt

SECRET #5226

[REDACTED]

this poem was written

and now you should
read it.

brilliance

mine came from
upbringing
pain
practise
isolation
recognition
depression
energy
Energy
ENERGY
!!!

...

questions?

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lies

The average person shakes 525,600
hands during his lifetime.
Songs without choruses are boring.
I am perfect; flawless beyond compare.
Things will never get better.
They're eating the cats, they're eating
the dogs!
Maybe he was just joking.
I'm fine.

truths

If you are reading this, you are alive.

If you are reading this, you are spending
your time well.

If you are reading this, you are embracing
the imperfections.

If you are reading this, you always have the
potential to improve.

If you are reading this, you should fact-
check what politicians say.

If you are reading this, he wasn't joking.

If you are reading this, I'm tired.

Document 012 (“Life”)

Oh,
isn't that a fleeting thing?
Isn't that impermanent?

Aren't there
lights
cameras
ACTION!
betrayals
lovers
political factions
winners
scientists
CEOs
journalists
engineers
friends and foes
readers
publishers

Document 012 (“Life”) *cont’d.*

writers
commentators
viewers
UFC fighters
new lawyers
unpaid interns
corrupt politicians
revolutionaries
terrorists
hosts on television
whites
blacks
something in-between
musicians
doctors
a young woman, only 19
women
children
and someone left unseen?

“What’s the reader doing?”

Nothing important, obviously.
Why else would
he be reading this?

he’s probably wearing glasses

And a suit, on the train
to work.

he could be in the car
waiting on a red light
glancing at his phone
to read

True.

he’s spying on us
what a
peeping tom

“He” could also be a she.
More like a
Peeping Jane.

“she” could be neither
peeping person

“What’s the reader doing?” *cont’d.*

Or all of the above.

all at the same time

Wait, is that possible?

it isn’t not possible

That’s a non-answer.

answers are just
food for the hunger
of truth
maybe you should fast

Touché.

But we still haven’t
answered the question.

What’s the reader doing?

what’s the reader doing

...

...

Wasting their time.

looking for certainty in the valley of doubt

Ryan Jacob
El-Quaradighi

